

Friday — English Home Language | Week 1

Paper 1: Comprehension · Visual Literacy · Paper 3: Writing Types · Vocabulary Notebook

1 — Paper 1: Comprehension Skills

CAPS Paper 1 tests your ability to read and respond to unseen texts. The three core reading strategies below are the foundation of every comprehension question.

The Three Reading Strategies

Skimming	Reading quickly to get the general idea or main topic. You are NOT reading every word. Run your eyes over headings, first sentences of paragraphs, and bold text.
Scanning	Searching for a specific piece of information — a name, date, number, or keyword. Your eyes move fast until they find the target.
Close Reading	Reading slowly and carefully to understand meaning, tone, language use, and detail. This is what you do when answering most comprehension questions.

■ When to use each one in an exam:

Skimming → first read of the passage (get the gist in 60 seconds)

Scanning → finding where the answer is in the text

Close Reading → understanding the answer precisely before you write

Key Comprehension Skills (CAPS Paper 1)

Literal	Answer is directly stated in the text. Find it, quote or paraphrase it.
Inferential	Answer is NOT stated. You must read between the lines — use clues in the text.
Tone	The writer's attitude or feeling — e.g. sarcastic, optimistic, critical, nostalgic.
Diction	The writer's word choice and why specific words were chosen.
Context clues	Using surrounding words/sentences to figure out the meaning of an unknown word.
Figurative lang.	Simile, metaphor, personification, hyperbole — and their effect on the reader.

Worked Examples

Passage extract (fictional):

"The city never slept. From the forty-second floor, Nomsa watched the river of headlights crawl below — a slow, relentless tide of commuters who had traded their dreams for deadlines. She pressed her forehead against the cold glass and wondered when she had done the same."

Example 1 — Literal question: Where is Nomsa?

Strategy: Scan for Nomsa's location.
Answer in text: '...the forty-second floor...'
Write: Nomsa is on the forty-second floor of a building, looking down at the city.

Example 2 — Inferential question: What does 'traded their dreams for deadlines' suggest about the commuters?

Strategy: Close read. No direct answer — must infer.
Clue 1: 'dreams' = personal ambitions/hopes
Clue 2: 'deadlines' = work obligations
Clue 3: 'traded' = gave one thing in exchange for another
Answer: The commuters have given up their personal ambitions in order to
meet the demands of their working lives.

Example 3 — Tone question: Identify the tone of the passage and justify.

Strategy: Look at word choices. What feeling do they create?
Evidence: 'never slept', 'relentless', 'traded dreams for deadlines', 'cold glass'
These words suggest exhaustion, loss, and resignation.
Tone: Melancholic / reflective.
Justify: The writer uses words like 'relentless' and 'cold' to create a mood of
weariness and quiet sadness.

2 — Paper 1: Visual Literacy

Visual Literacy questions in CAPS Paper 1 ask you to analyse images, cartoons, advertisements, graphs, or infographics. You need to read visual elements the same way you read written text.

Types of Visual Texts

Cartoon / Comic	Sequential images that tell a story or make a point. Look at speech bubbles, facial expressions, body language, and background.
Advertisement	Designed to persuade. Look at slogan, target audience, colour, imagery, and emotional appeal.
Graph / Chart	Data presented visually. Look at title, axes labels, trends, and anomalies.

Infographic	Combination of image and data to explain a concept. Look at hierarchy of information.
Photograph	Can be used as a text. Look at angle, focus, lighting, and what is included/excluded.

Key Visual Literacy Terms

Foreground/Background	What the image places in front vs behind — signals importance.
Connotation	The implied or emotional meaning of an image or colour beyond its literal meaning.
Body language	Posture, gesture, and facial expression that communicate meaning without words.
Camera angle	Low angle = subject appears powerful. High angle = subject appears weak/small.
Juxtaposition	Placing two contrasting elements side by side to highlight a point.
White space	Empty space in a design — used to direct focus or create a clean feel.

How to Answer a Visual Literacy Question

- **Identify** what type of visual text it is.
- **State** what you literally see (description).
- **Interpret** what it means or suggests (inference).
- **Link** to the purpose: what effect does it have on the audience?
- **Use evidence** — refer to specific visual elements by name.

Worked Example

Describe the cartoon: A large man in a suit sits at a desk overflowing with papers. A small child stands at the door, holding a drawing. The man does not look up.

What do I see? (literal): A businessman at a messy desk ignoring a child at the door.
What does it suggest? (inferential):
The man's size vs the child's size → power imbalance
Overflowing papers → overwhelmed by work
Not looking up → work takes priority over family
Effect on audience: Creates sympathy for the child. Critiques a culture that
prioritises career over relationships.
Tone: Critical / ironic

3 — Paper 3: The Four Writing Types

CAPS Paper 3 requires you to write one long piece (± 400 words) and one shorter piece (± 250 words). You must know the PURPOSE, STRUCTURE, and TONE of each writing type.

Essay (Discursive)

Purpose	To explore a topic from multiple angles. Presents a balanced argument.
Structure	Introduction → Argument 1 → Argument 2 → Counter-argument → Conclusion
Tone	Formal, objective, measured. Avoid first person (I) unless personal essay.
Key words	Furthermore, however, on the other hand, in conclusion, it is evident that.

Persuasive Writing

Purpose	To convince the reader to agree with your viewpoint.
Structure	Strong opening statement → 3 arguments with evidence → Call to action / Conclusion
Tone	Confident, direct, passionate. First person (I/we) is appropriate.
Key words	Clearly, undeniably, it is essential that, we must, the evidence shows.

Reflective Writing

Purpose	To reflect on a personal experience and what you learned from it.
Structure	Experience described → Feelings explored → Lessons learned → Future impact
Tone	Personal, introspective, honest. First person (I) throughout.
Key words	I realised, I felt, looking back, this taught me, I now understand.

Transactional Writing

Purpose	Functional writing for real-world purposes: letters, emails, reports, CVs, speeches.
Structure	Depends on format. Must follow the correct layout for the specific text type.
Tone	Varies: formal for letters/reports, semi-formal for emails. Match register to audience.
Key words	Dear Sir/Madam, I am writing to, Yours faithfully, With reference to.

■ Quick decision in the exam:

'Argue for/against' or 'discuss' → Essay or Persuasive

'Write about a time when...' → Reflective

'Write a letter / speech / email' → Transactional

4 — Vocabulary Notebook | Week 1

10 words per week. Learn the word, its part of speech, definition, and use it in a sentence. These build your diction marks in Paper 3.

#	Word	Type	Definition	Example sentence
1	Melancholy	adj. / noun	A deep, persistent sadness with no obvious cause.	<i>There was a melancholy silence in the room after the announcement.</i>
2	Ambivalent	adjective	Having mixed or contradictory feelings about something.	<i>She was ambivalent about the promotion — excited but nervous.</i>
3	Juxtapose	verb	To place two contrasting things side by side for effect.	<i>The photographer juxtaposed wealth and poverty in a single frame.</i>
4	Ostensibly	adverb	Apparently or seemingly, though not necessarily actually.	<i>He was ostensibly calm, but his hands betrayed his nerves.</i>
5	Rhetoric	noun	Persuasive language, especially in speeches or writing.	<i>The politician's rhetoric stirred the crowd but offered no solutions.</i>
6	Inference	noun	A conclusion reached by reasoning from evidence, not direct statement.	<i>From her tone, I drew the inference that she was displeased.</i>
7	Connotation	noun	An idea or feeling a word invokes beyond its literal meaning.	<i>The word 'snake' carries connotations of betrayal and deception.</i>
8	Poignant	adjective	Evoking a strong sense of sadness or regret.	<i>The final scene of the film was quietly poignant.</i>
9	Pragmatic	adjective	Dealing with things in a sensible, practical way rather than theoretically.	<i>We need a pragmatic solution, not an idealistic one.</i>
10	Lucid	adjective	Expressed clearly; easy to understand. Also: mentally clear.	<i>Her explanation was lucid and required no follow-up questions.</i>

Practice Questions

Use the passage below to answer Part A and Part B.

"Marcus had spent seventeen years building his company from a single rented garage into a "corporation that employed eight hundred people. He never missed a board meeting, never took a "holiday, and rarely saw his children before they went to bed. When the journalist asked him if he "had any regrets, Marcus paused — the longest pause of his life, it seemed — and then smiled his famous, practised smile. 'None whatsoever,' he said."

Part A — Comprehension

Q1 How many years did Marcus spend building his company?
• (Literal)

Q2 What does 'rarely saw his children before they went to bed' tell us
• about Marcus's priorities? (Inferential)

Q3 What is the tone of the passage? Identify TWO words or phrases
• that justify your answer.

Q4 Explain the effect of the phrase 'the longest pause of his life, it
• seemed'.

Q5 Do you think Marcus actually has no regrets? Justify your answer
• using evidence from the passage.

Part B — Visual Literacy (describe and analyse)

Q6 Name THREE types of visual text you could encounter in CAPS
• Paper 1.

Q7 What does a 'low camera angle' suggest about the subject of a
• photograph?

Q8 Explain the term 'connotation' and give ONE example using the
• colour red.

Q9 How does 'white space' function in an advertisement?
•

Q10. A cartoon shows a large factory pouring smoke into a bright blue sky. A small child stands below, coughing. What point is the cartoonist making? Use visual literacy terms in your answer.

Part C — Writing Types

Q1 Name the FOUR writing types covered in CAPS Paper 3.
1.

Q1 Which writing type would you use if the question says: 'Write a letter to your local newspaper about a problem in your community'?
2.

Q1 What is the key difference between a discursive essay and a persuasive piece?
3.

Q1 A reflective piece asks you to write about a time you failed at something. Write your OPENING sentence only.
4.

Q1 List THREE linking words or phrases suitable for a persuasive piece.
5.

Part D — Vocabulary

Q1 Use the word **melancholy** correctly in a sentence of your own.
6.

Q1 What is the difference between **ostensibly** and **actually**? Give an example.
7.

Q1 Choose any THREE words from this week's list and write one sentence that uses all three.
8.

ANSWER KEY

Only look here after you have attempted every question.

Part A — Comprehension

Q1	How many years?	Seventeen years
.	Stated directly: 'seventeen years building his company' — literal question, find and quote.	
Q2	Children — priorities	Work is his priority over family
.	He rarely sees his children → career placed above personal relationships. This is inferential — the text doesn't say he doesn't care; we infer it from his actions.	
Q3	Tone	Ironic / melancholic
.	Evidence: 'famous, practised smile' → the word 'practised' suggests the smile is not genuine. 'None whatsoever' after the longest pause = contradiction. The tone is ironic.	
Q4	Effect of 'longest pause'	Creates suspense; suggests he is hiding something
.	The pause contradicts his answer. It implies he does have regrets but will not admit them. Effect: makes the reader question his honesty.	
Q5	Does Marcus have regrets?	Yes — implied by the pause and 'practised smile'
.	Evidence: (1) 'the longest pause of his life' — hesitation before denying regret. (2) 'famous, practised smile' — not a genuine reaction. Both suggest the answer 'None whatsoever' is not truthful.	

Part B — Visual Literacy

Q6	Three visual text types	Any three: cartoon, advertisement, photograph, graph/chart, infographic
.		
Q7	Low camera angle	Subject appears powerful, dominant, or threatening
.		
The viewer looks up at the subject — creates a sense that the subject is larger or more important.		

Q8	Connotation + red	Connotation = implied/emotional meaning beyond literal. Red = danger, passion, urgency, warning.
.	The literal meaning of red is a colour. Its connotation depends on context — stop signs, hearts, blood.	
Q9	White space in ads	Directs the viewer's eye to the main message; creates a premium, uncluttered feel
.		
Q10.	Factory cartoon analysis	The cartoonist criticises industrial pollution and its human cost.
	Juxtaposition: the large factory (power/industry) vs the small child (vulnerability/innocence). The bright blue sky creates irony — it should be clean but is being destroyed. Body language (child coughing) creates sympathy. The size difference emphasises the power imbalance between corporations and ordinary people.	

Part C — Writing Types

Q11.	Four writing types	Essay (discursive), Persuasive, Reflective, Transactional
Q12.	Letter to newspaper	Transactional — a formal letter is a transactional text type.
Q13.	Essay vs persuasive	Essay explores multiple sides and stays balanced. Persuasive argues one side only and aims to convince.
Q14.	Reflective opening sentence	Accept any first-person opening that grounds the reader in a specific moment of failure.
	Example: 'I had practised for weeks, but the moment the examiner called my name, everything I knew seemed to dissolve.'	
Q15.	Three persuasive linking words	Any three from: Clearly, Undeniably, Furthermore, It is essential that, The evidence shows, We must, Without doubt.

Part D — Vocabulary

Q16.	Use melancholy	Accept any grammatically correct sentence where melancholy expresses deep, lingering sadness.
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Example: 'A melancholy mood settled over the house after the funeral.'

Q1
7. Ostensibly vs actually

Ostensibly = how something appears on the surface. Actually = the reality beneath.

Example: 'He was ostensibly relaxed, but actually terrified.'

Q1
8. Three words in one sentence

Accept any fluent sentence using three vocabulary words correctly in context.

Example: 'The politician's rhetoric was ostensibly pragmatic, but his melancholy expression betrayed his uncertainty.'